

was three and he showed immense precocity. He gave private recitals from the age of five and made his public debut at age 10, offering, as an encore, to play from memory any of Beethoven's 32 piano sonatas—an astonishing prospect at such a young age, especially given the difficulty of many of Beethoven's sonatas. His talents were not confined to music: he excelled at Latin and mathematics, and developed serious interests in subjects ranging from archaeology to astronomy.

Musical tours and tragedy

From 1848 to 1853, Saint-Saëns studied at the Paris Conservatoire, then became organist at the church of St. Merry. His Symphony No. 1 was successfully premiered in 1855 and by this time he was already winning golden praise from musicians of the caliber of Berlioz and Rossini. In 1858, he moved from St. Merry to take up the high-status post of organist at the Madeleine church (see [box](#)).

He remained at the Madeleine church for almost 20 years, until 1877, thereafter pursuing his career independently, traveling to perform as a pianist and conductor not just in Europe, but also in North and South America and the Far East.

Although he seems to have been predominantly homosexual, Saint-Saëns married in 1875. His 19-year-old bride was half his age and the marriage was a complete disaster. The couple had two children, both of whom died as infants in 1878, one after falling from a window. In 1881, Saint-Saëns walked out on his wife and never saw her again.